

**ORAKZAI IN MODERN PAKISTAN**

“From a historic frontier region to a district within a changing Pakistan.”

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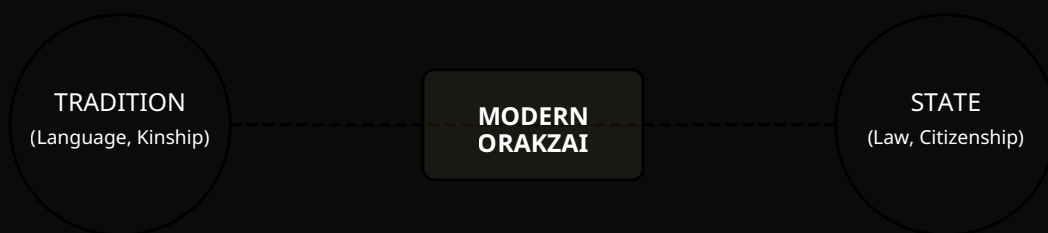
Modern Orakzai is part of a Pakistan that has changed repeatedly within living memory. The mountains remain. The valleys remain. Family names, languages and memories remain. But the political and administrative world around them has changed. Orakzai was once governed within the former system of the Federally Administered Tribal Areas. In 2018, that constitutional arrangement changed. The former FATA territories were merged with Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. Orakzai became a district of the province. Courts, provincial departments, elections, development institutions and public administration increasingly became part of the same constitutional framework that governs the rest of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. But integration is not a single event. It is a process. And modern Orakzai is still being shaped by the relationship between history, citizenship, institutions, development and community life.



**“The structural integration of Orakzai into the Pakistani civic landscape.”**

#### WHAT DOES “MODERN ORAKZAI” MEAN?

Modernity in Orakzai does not mean abandoning cultural identity. Instead, it is a synthesis where tradition meets the state, law, and technology. A community can maintain its language, family structures, and hospitality while simultaneously participating in formal education, digital communication, and national politics.<sup>7</sup>



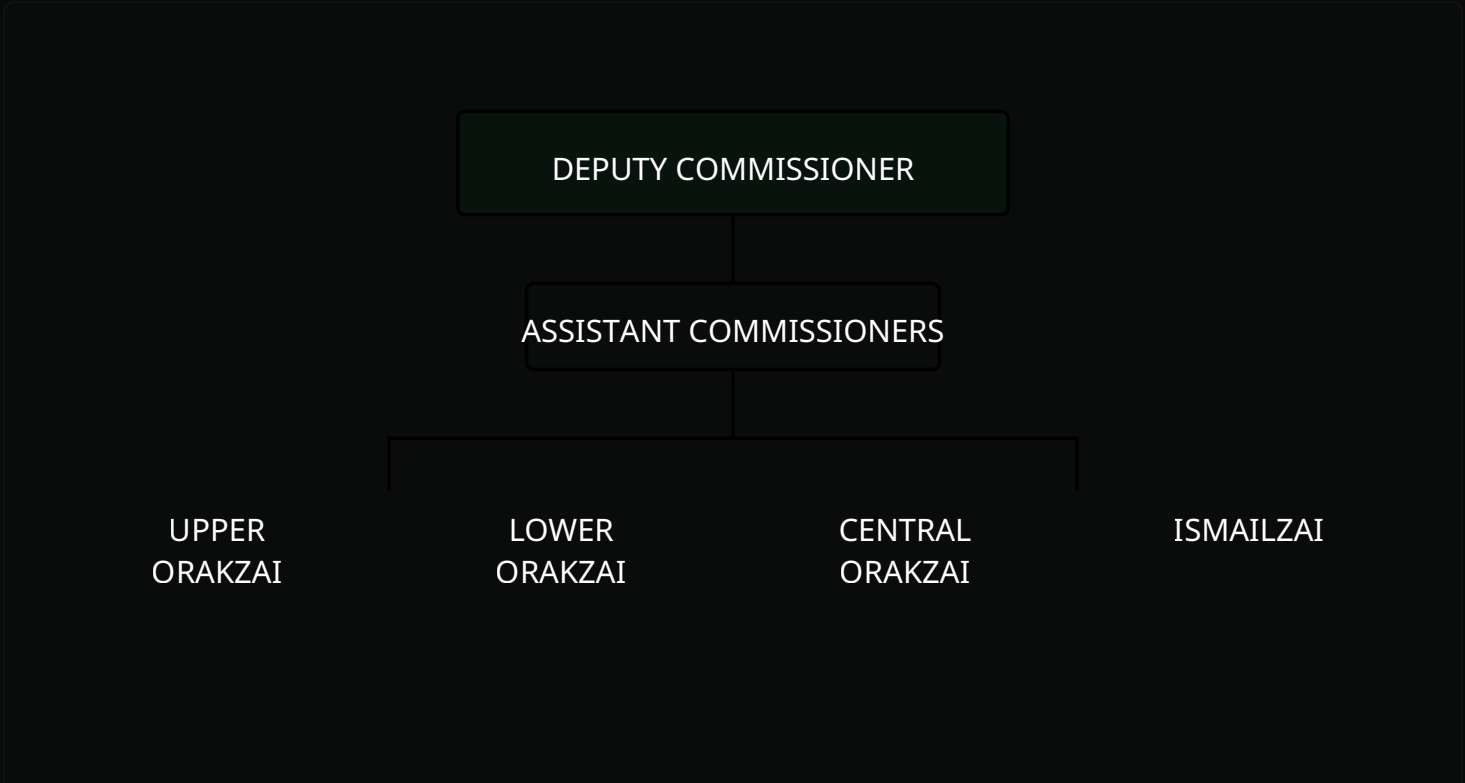
**“The synthesis of tradition and statehood in the modern Orakzai identity.”**

The 25th Constitutional Amendment of 2018 was the defining moment for modern Orakzai. It abolished the former Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) and merged the region into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. This transformation brought the district into the same constitutional, legal, and administrative framework that governs the rest of Pakistan.<sup>1 6</sup>



ADMINISTRATIVE STRUCTURE

Today, Orakzai is a district within the Kohat Division. It is headed by a Deputy Commissioner (DC) and is subdivided into four tehsils: Lower Orakzai, Upper Orakzai, Central Orakzai, and Ismailzai. This structure replaces the former Political Agency system with a standard provincial administrative hierarchy.<sup>5</sup>



“The administrative subdivision of Orakzai District.”

JUSTICE AND THE RULE OF LAW

One of the most profound changes has been the establishment of the formal judiciary. District Courts Orakzai became operational in February 2019 at Baber Mela, marking the end of the Frontier Crimes Regulation (FCR) and the beginning of constitutional judicial access for all residents.<sup>2</sup>

FCR ERA

CONSTITUTIONAL COURTS (2019)

FORMAL JUSTICE

“The shift from customary/administrative justice to the formal rule of law.”

THE 2023 CENSUS DASHBOARD

The 2023 Digital Census provides the most current demographic profile of the district. While Orakzai remains entirely rural in its locality classification, its population density and household size reflect a community deeply rooted in its valley floors.<sup>3</sup>

387,561

TOTAL POPULATION

7.4

AVG HOUSEHOLD SIZE

0

URBAN POPULATION

252

PERSONS PER KM<sup>2</sup>

Integration has also brought direct political representation. Residents now vote for their own representatives in the National Assembly (NA-36) and the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Provincial Assembly (PK-94), ensuring their voice is heard in the legislative halls of the province and the nation.<sup>4</sup>

COMMUNITY

VOTER

ELECTION

REPRESENTATION

“The chain of political participation in the modern electoral system.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Modernity is not an end point; it is a conversation. For Orakzai, being part of modern Pakistan means finding a way to carry the strength of our history into the structure of the modern state. The 2018 merger was a landmark, but the real work happens every day in the classrooms, the courtrooms, and the council halls. We are no longer a frontier to be managed; we are a district to be served. Integration is about more than laws and boundaries; it is about ensuring that every child in the Orakzai valleys has the same rights and opportunities as a child in Peshawar or Islamabad. We are Orakzai, and we are Pakistan—and in that synthesis, we find our future.

“WE ARE ORAKZAI, AND WE ARE PAKISTAN.”

